

CoARA Action Plan

SDU Action Plan 2025 – 2026

In accordance with the CoARA Agreement on Reforming Research Assessment.

Preamble

After an internal consultation process, SDU signed the CoARA agreement in November 2022. The agreement includes a common set of principles that form a starting point for a gradual cultural change in the European research world's assessment of research, with a view to this occurring to a greater extent based on more qualitative methods. SDU contributes to the efforts to reform research assessment, and the university participates in activities under the umbrella of the Coalition for Advancing Research Assessment (CoARA).

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University of Southern Denmark

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1. University of Southern Denmark (SDU)

Statement concerning CoARA

The strategical aim of the University of Southern Denmark (SDU) is to be known and recognized for ground-breaking and transformative research, and to become a world leader in several research areas: It is only by retaining, developing and attracting the greatest talents that we can create the excellent environments needed to create value for and with society (cf. SDU's strategy).

These goals require excellent research environments that stimulate talent development, as well as ambitious researchers and students, achieved e.g. through an excellent organizational and physical framework that attract, develop, and release talent. To achieve that objective, SDU must ensure a freely engaging and stimulating university environment, that support good opportunities for continuous development.

Therefore, SDU agrees that the assessment of research, researchers and research organizations must recognize the diversity of outputs, practices and activities that maximizes the quality and impact of research – and that this requires basing assessment primarily on qualitative judgement, for which peer-review is central, supported by responsible use of quantitative indicators.

SDU supports the general recommendation of the CoARA Agreement on Reforming Research Assessment and commits to participate in the shared vision of change in assessment practices for research, researchers and research performing organizations with the overarching goal to maximize the quality and impact of research: For the sake of a broader perspective on the appropriate use of data, all calculations and analyses carried out at SDU are accompanied by data ethics considerations that aim to ensure a responsible interpretation and use of the displayed information.

SDU recognizes the coalition's goal of being an inclusive and collaborative space to advance together towards a higher quality, more impactful and efficient and inclusive research system.

2. Taking action

Actionable themes

SDU will implement changes in assessment practices by committing to several actionable themes underpinning SDU's strategical position: Career and recruitment, Gender Equality, Open Science, and Societal Impact. Other related themes include measures and developments in the context of research integrity and funding strategy.

Theme	Q3-2023	Q1-Q4: 2024	Q1-Q4: 2025	Q1-Q4: 2026
Timeline	Signing	Coordination	Implementation	Evaluation
T1: HR Excellence	Initiation	Drafting application	Application for award	Implementation
T2: Careers and recruitment	Approving Project	Drafting Guidelines	Approval	Implementation
T3: Gender Equality	Ongoing	Ongoing	Ongoing	Ongoing
T4: Open Science	Revising Policy	Approving Policy	Implementation	Implementation
T5: Societal Impact	Initiation	Drafting Model	Collaboration	Implementation

Actions specifically related to these themes are listed on page 10.

3. Themes

1. HR Excellence

SDU supports researchers in the development of their academic careers, by pursuing the best possible HR policy. Therefore, SDU is currently in the first phase of obtaining the European Commission's recognition of SDU's commitment to fostering good working conditions and career development for researchers by complying with The European Charter for Researchers and the Code of Conduct for the recruitment of researchers.

HR Excellence in Research emphasizes an attractive and stimulating research environment characterized by supportive and inclusive institutional frameworks. The European Charter for Researchers and the Code of Conduct for Recruitment focus on 4 themes:

1. Ethics and Research Integrity: Compliance with ethical standards and professional responsibility
2. Recruitment and Selection: Open, transparent, and merit-based recruitment processes
3. Working Conditions: Attractive career development, equal opportunities, and balance between work and other areas of life
4. Training and Development: Continuous professional development and mentoring.

Actions

Actions 1 through 4: SDU is applying for the HR Excellence in Research Award, as part of SDU's Strategy 2030, and to this end, we have drawn up a comprehensive action plan.

2. Framework Policy for Academic Career Advancement and Assessment

SDU aims to recruit and invest in inspired academics capable of pushing boundaries of research-based knowledge, teaching and knowledge dissemination, entrepreneurship and innovation.

SDU's Framework Policy for Academic Career Advancement and Assessment furthers this objective. Its intent is to clarify SDU's approach to academic merit and to engender transparent and meaningful career advancement criteria in the departments of the university. It is designed to guide and reinforce local initiative. The framework builds on the CoARA principles and shares CoARA's desire to promote a higher quality, a fairer, more inclusive and more impactful approach to the advancement of the quality and impact of diverse research activities and practices.

It is the ambition that a modernized merit system must ensure a greater degree of clarity and transparency of criteria for both career advancement across employment categories and career development within tenured positions. This activity hence lends to the CoARA Core Commitments and by appreciating and incentivizing advancement in all forms of research-based knowledge.

Actions

Action 5: To establish common criteria for advancement of research staff through guidelines and university policies.

3. Gender Equality

SDU's progressive Gender Equality Vision Statement substantiates the university's commitment to informed, continuous, conscious, and ambitious equality efforts and helps inform the direction of our Gender Equality Plans (GEPs) across all faculties at SDU. SDU's approach to gender equality includes being attentive to diversity, inclusion, and power dynamics that produce inequalities in recruitment and research assessment, as two areas of crucial importance.

To best qualify the work being done at SDU, our Gender Equality Team (GET) participates in the EU's two leading projects on inclusive GEP development and Gender Equality Excellence: INSPIRE and GENDERACTIONplus, which will help inform the work on recruitment and career progression in the coming years.

SDU's GEP provides the framework for SDU's equality work and ensures systematicity, coordination, direction and ongoing support and qualification of the initiatives that take place on all organisational levels. SDU's GEP thus comprises a formalised, processual framework, and support for and quality assurance of SDU's collected GE efforts. This includes initiating the GEP work at each department and division, assisting Heads of Departments and Heads of Units in defining relevant activities and areas, as well as taking part in facilitating the implementation of the activities. A central part of this work is raising awareness regarding inequalities and unconscious bias. Thus, SDU's Gender Equality Team provides expert sparring and facilitates workshops at the department level across faculties in order to address and work with unconscious bias and discrimination in recruitment and research assessment, which includes training members of hiring committees, amongst other things.

Gender Dimension in Research (GDiR) implements a structure for network meetings and workshops for sharing knowledge, supervision etc. with research supporters. SDU's Research and Innovation Organisation (SDU RIO) and SDU's Gender Equality Team collaborate together to provide expert, qualified, ongoing support in the development of resources, tools, workshops and targeted consultancy to support researchers who seek to integrate systematic analyses that take diversity parameters – including sex and gender – into account in research design, theory, methods, ethics, data, output and impact. Training and workshops on GDiR are offered regularly and are a part of SDU's internal competence building.

The Mentoring for Change Programme will be offered to all new PhD students at the Faculty of Health Sciences (approx. 130 yearly) and a selected group of postdocs and assistant professors at the faculty. PhD students will be enrolled twice a year and others once a year.

Actions

Action 6: SDU's GEP provides the framework for SDU's equality work.

4. Open Science

SDU recognizes Open Science as one of its guiding principles that have the potential to magnify the influence of its research to the world. SDU commits to promote Open Science by encouraging and supporting research processes and tools that spur collaboration, enabling new working models and new social relationships, stimulating the dissemination of knowledge and the accessibility and re-usability of research outputs, encouraging open access to publications and data, and building the necessary infrastructure, skills, and incentives to support Open Science. SDU supports and empowers the transition to Open Science through education, training, and awareness-raising actions, along with the provision of the necessary infrastructure, services, and resources to support this transition.

SDU's Open Science Policy support departments, researchers, and research support staff by providing guidance regarding the implementation of Open Science practices, e.g. that:

- Research data is recognized as a valuable resource and a Data Management Plan (DMP) is considered as an essential part of any major research project. The management of research data should reflect best practices, code of conduct, security considerations, ethical protocols in the respective field of research. It should follow the FAIR principles, comply to the National strategy for FAIR research data management and adhere to the Danish Code of Conduct for Research Integrity.
- Publications and relevant research data are made as open as it is sensible, to contribute to the advancement of science, to accelerate breakthroughs, to pave the way for new innovations that improve society, and to support research findings and transparency.
- Research Data Management is recognized as a vital component of good scientific practice enabling trust in research.
- All researchers are urged to create an Open Researcher and Contributor ID (ORCID) as well as to claim and update their appropriate researcher IDs and to connect them to Pure to increase the visibility, and recognition of their work.
- To assess quality of research and evaluate performance of researchers, SDU will compliment journal-based metrics with consideration of Open Science and additional relevant research activities as stated in the COARA Agreement on Reforming Research Assessment.

Thus, SDU will adhere to these agreements and not use journal-based metrics, such as Journal Impact Factors, as a surrogate measure of the quality of research articles, to assess a researcher's contribution, or in hiring and promotion.

Actions

Actions 7 through 10: Update university policy and implementing revised institute guidelines.

5. Societal Impact

According to the Open Science Policy, SDU supports departments, researchers, and research support staff by providing guidance regarding the implementation of practices that assist the engagement of citizens, civic society and other stakeholders in research for a more inclusive and participatory society better equipped to handle the profound transformations of the coming years is encouraged whenever this is feasible or makes sense for the project. There is evidence that this can increase the impact of research in society.

Actions

Actions 11 and 12: Citizen Science and integration in research support; Citizen Science and the development of methods to evaluate and enhance the Societal Impact of research.

6. Other related themes

SDU's Funding Strategy is a related theme through its six phases of organizational research support: Exploration, clarification, dialogue & data, analysis & interpretation, Knowledge integration, and assessment of impact.

Research Integrity and Responsible Conduct of Research, as also addressed through Theme 1, is a related theme in a wider context through SDU's commitment to the advancement of science and dissemination of knowledge to the benefit of society by adopting practices on open, reliable, reproducible, accountable, and responsible research following the basic principles of the European Code of Conduct for Research Integrity. All research associated with SDU must strive for trustworthiness and high integrity; this includes honesty, transparency, and accountability as defined by the National Code for Responsible Conduct of Research.

4. Actions

1. List of actions

Action	Description	Theme	Starting	Internally Responsible	Commitment
A1	Ethical and Professional Aspects	T1	Q2, 2025	REC, Practice Committee, RIO, Library, HR	1, 7
A2	Recruitment and Selection	T1	Q2, 2025	HR, GET, COM	1-4, 7
A3	Working Conditions	T1	Q2, 2025	DIAS, HR, GET, Health and Safety	1,5
A4	Training and Development	T1	Q2, 2025	HR, Centre for Teaching and Learning	1,7
A5	Common criteria for the advancement of research staff	T2	Q2, 2025	Deans	1-4, 5-7
A6	GET implementation	T3	2025	GET Team	1, 5, 7
A7	New institute Open Science guidelines	T4	Q2, 2025	Deans	1-4, 7
A8	Evaluation and actual use of a new Open Science indicator (OADO)	T4	Q3, 2025	Library	1, 3, 6
A9	Introducing the SDU Open Science Awards	T4	Q4, 2025	Library	1, 3, 5, 6, 7
A10	Dataverse Installation in SDU	T4	Q4, 2025	Library, eScience Center	1, 5, 7, 10
A11	Citizen Science and integration in research support (pilots)	T5	Q2-Q4 2025	Library, RIO	1
A12	Citizen Science and the development of methods to evaluate and enhance the Societal Impact of research	T5	2026	Library	1, 5, 7

Other activities

Internal coordination and national collaboration on CoARA. Participate in the organization of the National Danish conference on the reform of research assessment during the Danish EU chairmanship in 2025 (Q4). The University Library is responsible for coordinating these supplementing activities.

5. Commitments

The CoARA Core Commitments (i.e. what to change) and Supporting Commitments (i.e. how to change) as defined by the the Coalition for the Advancement of Research Assessment are as follows:

Core Commitment 1

Recognise the diversity of contributions to, and careers in, research in accordance with the needs and nature of the research.

Core Commitment 2

Base research assessment primarily on qualitative evaluation for which peer review is central, supported by responsible use of quantitative indicators.

Core Commitment 3

Abandon inappropriate uses in research assessment of journal- and publication based metrics, in particular inappropriate uses of Journal Impact Factor (JIF) and h-index.

Core Commitment 4

Avoid the use of rankings of research organisations in research assessment.

Supporting Commitment 5

Commit resources to reforming research assessment as is needed to achieve the organisational changes committed to.

Supporting Commitment 6

Review and develop research assessment criteria, tools and processes.

Supporting Commitment 7

Raise awareness of research assessment reform and provide transparent communication, guidance, and training on assessment criteria and processes as well as their use.

Supporting Commitment 8

Exchange practices and experiences to enable mutual learning within and beyond the Coalition.

Supporting Commitment 9

Communicate progress made on adherence to the Principles and implementation of the Commitments.

Supporting commitment 10

Evaluate practices, criteria and tools based on solid evidence and the state-of-the-art in research on re-search, and make data openly available for evidence gathering and research



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